Pillow Talk

By Peter Tolan

Doug and Aaron are discovered in the tiny bedroom of a mobile home. The room is dominated by a smallish double bed, and bags and luggage crowd the floor making passage around the bed difficult. Doug sits on the edge of the bed dressing a wound on his ankle while Aaron calls through the open door to his (unseen and unheard by us) grandmother.

AARON: *(calling off)* No, Grandma . . . we're all set. No, we're fine. No, I don't think we need any more blankets. Thank you. Goodnight.

DOUG: *(calling off)* Goodnight, Mrs. Markell. *(listening)* No, it's fine. The bleeding's stopped . . . *(listening)* No, I'm sure Pookie didn't mean it. It was my fault. I shouldn't have been doing what I was doing.

AARON: What were you doing?

DOUG: *(quietly)* Standing next to the little bastard. *(calling off)* Uh-huh . . . no, I'm sure he's a very sweet ferret. It's no problem.

AARON: *(calling off)* Grandma? Grandma, we're going to sleep now so stop talking, okay? Well, I love you too. Yeah, I'll see you in the morning. Goodnight. *(quietly to Doug)* She doesn't get too many visitors.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *Aaron and Doug have been friends since childhood.*
ACTOR 2: *But when they are put in a situation where sharing a bed is the only option . . .*
ACTOR 1: *Well, anyone who know anything about awkward slumber parties or toxic masculinity will understand how this plays out.*
TOGETHER: *Pillow Talk by Peter Tolan*

AARON: *(Doug starts to exit the room)* Where are you going?

DOUG: Now you be brave, young fella. I'm just down the hall.

AARON: Doug, where are you going?

DOUG: To my room.

AARON: Yeah. Right here. We're sleeping in here.

DOUG: We? We who?

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AARON: We we. You and me we. Here. In the bed. Where did you think you were going to sleep?

DOUG: Down at the end of the hall. I thought there was another bedroom.

AARON: Doug, this is a mobile home. There isn't another of anything. They give you one kitchen, one living room, one bathroom, one bedroom.

DOUG: *(brightly)* Okay . . . fine, fine. Yeah.

AARON: Goodnight. *(covers his face with a pillow. Doug considers for a moment, then begins to moan and stretch)*

DOUG: You know, all this driving . . . this is one hell of a long trip. Sitting in that Honda fifteen hours every day . . . and this is only the first day! The old back's already begging for mercy. I'd better sleep on the floor.

AARON: *(removes the pillow from his face)* You want to sleep on the floor?

DOUG: Don't want to. Have to. My back needs the support . . . a hard surface. Maybe I can sleep on the floor in the living room.

AARON: You want to go out there and sleep on the floor? Go ahead. Tomorrow morning we'll find your shoes and a 155 pound ferret. *(flops back down on his pillow)*

DOUG: I forgot about Pookie. Damn. I knew I should have killed him when I had the chance. You know, you kill anything named Pookie, you're doing the community at large a great service. People would be stopping you in the street . . . "You killed Pookie? God bless you . . .

AARON: *(sits up again)* Doug . . . please. I'm tired. I need sleep. The sandman's here and he's backing up the truck. Lie down. Go to sleep. Now. *(puts the pillow back over his face. Doug thinks, then gingerly sits on the edge of the bed. Pause. Aaron lifts up one edge of his pillow and looks at Doug)* Strange. The light is still on. What could this mean?

DOUG: Can I tell you something? *(quietly)* I have never. . . I've never slept with a man before.

AARON: *(considers this)* Really. That's odd. I had you pegged as the kind of guy who's slept with hundreds of men.

DOUG: You know what I mean. I've never slept with a man . . . in the same bed.

AARON: What . . . not even when you were a kid? Like when you were in Scouts or something?

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DOUG: I wasn't in Scouts. I was in Chess Club. Sleeping together wasn't allowed. I think they figured it would take our minds off the game.

AARON: Uh-huh. *(pause)* So . . . what do you think's going to happen? You get into bed, close your little eyes, tomorrow morning you wake up rested, relaxed, with a huge hickey.

DOUG: *(concerned)* Funny. That's very funny. I'm trying to tell you about a serious thing, and all you do is . . .

AARON: *(laughing)* I'm sorry, I'm sorry.

DOUG: I hope you're having a good time mocking my discomfort.

AARON: Goodnight.

DOUG: Goodnight. *(Aaron clicks off the light as Doug reclines slowly. After a pause, Aaron rolls over so that his body is turned toward Doug, who clicks the light on)* Hello. You're facing in my direction.

AARON: Yes. I usually sleep facing this way. Is this a problem?

DOUG: I feel like you're looking at me. Could you turn the other way? *(Aaron grumbles loudly through his teeth, grabs the covers and violently turns himself to face away from Doug)* Thank you. Goodnight. *(clicks the light off and starts to settle in for the night. A pause, then Aaron shifts around trying to get comfortable. After a few moves, Doug clicks the light on)*

DOUG: I'm trying to sleep here; you're flailing around like it's a Dance Marathon!

AARON: You made me turn around, this is not the direction I usually sleep in, I'm trying to get comfortable!

DOUG: Why don't you just maul me and get it over with?

AARON: I never even came close to touching you! I'm sorry, Doug . . . *(turning to face Doug)* but I sleep facing this way, this is the way I'm going to sleep. Final warning. Sleep or be killed. *(Doug takes one of Aaron's pillows and one of his own and puts them in a line down the middle of the bed)* I don't believe this. You're making a wall? You know, I don't think I've ever said this to you before, but you're a seething, twisted mass of neuroses. You really are.

DOUG: We all have our little quirks.

AARON: I agree. Why you've decided to lump them all together into one evening, I don't know.

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But now it's time for you and me *(motioning to the wall of pillows)* and the Great Wall of China to go to sleep. *(clicks off the light. A pause, then Doug clicks it back on)*

DOUG: I won't be able to sleep if you're mad at me. I can't sleep if I think someone's mad at me.

AARON: *(trying to control himself)* All right. Look. I'm not mad at you. I was only trying to point out that you might have a problem.

DOUG: Oh, that's great.

AARON: Look, it's nothing. You're physically uptight, that's all. You don't like to be touched so you close yourself off. You're a closed person. Come on, it's not like I'm telling you something you don't know. Goodnight.

DOUG: Well, that's a little strong . . .

AARON: Anybody who puts pillows down the middle of the bed is scared of something. Admit it.

DOUG: It's a homo thing, isn't it? I'm serious. You know why I'm having so much trouble with this? Because I never had a homosexual thing as a kid. *(pause)* Did you?

AARON: *(interrupting)* Don't even ask!

DOUG: I thought we were such great old friends. You won't tell me about your homosexual experiences? . . . Timmy Loomis and I used to write our names in the snow. We'd *pee* in the snow and write our names. Is that a homosexual thing?

AARON: Well, I think we'd need a handwriting analysis before we could make that determination . . .

DOUG: *(a pause as Doug thinks)* Okay. When Timmy Loomis and I were in the fourth grade, we did this thing . . .

AARON: *(sits up abruptly)* You and Timmy Loomis again! What was it with you guys? Didn't you have any toys? Trucks or something like that to keep your hands occupied?

DOUG: We used to touch tongues.

AARON: What?

DOUG: We'd stick out our tongues and touch them together. Does that count?

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AARON: *(thinks for a second and then nods assuredly)* Yes.

DOUG: You think so?

AARON: Oh, yeah. Touching tongues? Definite homosexual experience. Very high on the list. *Ding* And there's the bell, end of discussion! Go to sleep and stop worrying because you don't want to touch me and I sure as hell don't want to touch you! Okay?

DOUG: Okay. Goodnight. *(Aaron clicks the light off. A pause, then Doug clicks the light back on)* This is going to sound strange. I'm a little offended by that last remark you made. You think I'm ugly, is that it? . . . An ugly, short, balding guy.

AARON: *(trying to hold it together)* Doug! No! I do not think you're an ugly guy! That's not what I meant when I said I didn't want to touch you. It was just my attempt to assure you that such an action is not and probably never will be on my personal agenda of things to do. Goodnight. *(clicks the light off)*

DOUG: I don't know what your problem is . . .

AARON: *(jumps up and turns on Doug)* I'll tell you my problem! I'm trying to get a little sleep and all I hear is a lunatic talking about *peeing* in the snow and sleeping on the floor and putting the pillows down the middle of the bed! And now . . . now you have the nerve to tell me you're offended because I don't want to touch you? I'm going insane! You want to sleep in a closet? Go sleep in a closet! You want to be touched? I'll touch you!

(Aaron lunges at Doug and starts grabbing at him. Doug tries to fight him off, but he's ticklish and all he can do is laugh hysterically. The door swings open and light from the hall spills into the room. Grandma has heard all the noise and comes to investigate. Both men freeze, Aaron nearly on top of Doug, as they realize what's happened.)

AARON: Grandma! *(leaps off the bed and turns on the light)* I'm sorry. . . did we wake you? *(listening)* Well, I don't want to go into too much detail . . . Doug and I were sort of . . . wrestling, I guess. *(listening, then running across the bed to get to the door)* No, it's nothing like Cousin Duane . . . please believe that. No there's no need to talk to Mom and Dad. I'm sorry we got you up. Just go back to bed and we'll be quiet. I love you. Goodnight. *(closes the door and stands, stunned -- to Doug)* We're not going to talk about this . . . ever.

DOUG: Maybe we should.

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AARON: No. We are guys. Guys do not worry about sleeping in the same bed. They do not talk about it. They shut up, they get it over with, and then it's done. Goodnight. *(reaches up and clicks the light off)* I'm going to tell her that you were having a seizure, and I was trying to keep you from swallowing your tongue when she walked in.

DOUG: You're pathetic.

AARON: No, Doug . . . I'm screwed. As soon as my grandmother wakes up . . . the second her eyes open . . . she's going to think, "Now, what was it I had to do first thing? Oh, that's right. I have to call Dick and Sheila and tell them their son's a homo!"

DOUG: You're blowing this way out of proportion . . . What are you trying to hide? Tell her the truth. Just say you were helping me get over my physical intimacy problem.

AARON: It was the middle of the night. She woke up, she only saw us for three seconds. She went back to sleep. It's highly possible that she's forgotten the whole thing.

DOUG: It's highly possible. But what if she hasn't?

AARON: No problem. We sit down to breakfast. We test the water. "How did you sleep last night, Grandma? I hope we didn't wake you." If she says no, she's forgotten, I'm safe. If she says yes - and she remembers everything - then we go into Operation Confuse Grandma. We deny. Totally. We shrug. And then, we push her over the edge. You look down at Pookie and you say, totally straight, "Pookie seems so nice. Has he ever bitten anyone?" And that does it! She's completely lost!

DOUG: You're trading your grandmother's mental health for your own!

AARON: Only if she remembers.

DOUG: You're really threatened, aren't you? . . . You're my best friend.

AARON: Great. Me and Timmy Loomis.

DOUG: Fine. Be a shit. You're still my best friend. I'm not sure I ever told you before, and I thought it might help.

AARON: Oh, yeah. It helps a lot. I'll tell my grandmother we're best friends and that'll settle the whole thing. (muttering) If only I was driving a pick-up with a gun rack. What can I do? I'll fix something. If nothing needs fixing, I'll break something, then I'll fix it . . . *(sees Doug getting*

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undressed) What are you doing?

DOUG: I'm getting undressed. I don't like sleeping in my clothes. *(jumps into bed and starts taking the pillow wall apart)* Tonight is a small piece of a much larger puzzle. It's new territory. I'm crossing the country. New places. A whole new outlook every day. If I've made this much progress on the first night, imagine what the rest of the trip will be like! *(lies back. and closes his eyes as Aaron sits up, his eyes wide)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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